



SHANKAR

Gulf of GLOOM

Kerala's money order economy will come under severe strain as over half-a-million Malayalees working in the Gulf are expected to lose their jobs due to the recession

| By M.G. Radhakrishnan |

Sakthikulangara literally means the coast of strength. For a decade and more, the well-built, skilled young fishermen of this tiny fishing hamlet on the Arabian Sea coast in Kerala's Kollam district were prized workers in a string of super luxury construction projects in Dubai. The fairy tale projects included the multi-billion dollar World Island, consisting of 300 private luxury islands spread out in the shape of five continents, and the stunning Palm Islands. European contractors and marine dredging companies hired these young men from Sakthikulangara to Dubai to work on the reclamation work not only because they cost less than the Russian and East European deep sea divers, but they didn't

need diving gear, including oxygen cylinders.

In recent months, these young men of Sakthikulangara have had their livelihood taken away. Since the beginning of the year, more than 1,000 persons have returned from Dubai to Sakthikulangara, their jobs lost, some believe for ever. Most of the projects have come to a screeching halt due to the global recession and drastic fall in oil prices. The European dredging companies which had hired them stopped work indefinitely as payments due to them from contractors had stopped. "The company said it will call us when the work begins again. But nobody knows when that will be," says Joy William, a 40-year-old quality assistant with a Belgian company working at the Palm Island project